

Engaging Exam-Oriented Students in Communicative Language Teaching by ‘Packaging’ Learning English Through Songs as Exam Practice

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journals.sagepub.com/home/rel**Kevin Wai-Ho Yung** 

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Abstract

Literature has long been used as a tool for language teaching and learning. In the New Academic Structure in Hong Kong, it has become an important element in the senior secondary English language curriculum to promote communicative language teaching (CLT) with a process-oriented approach. However, as in many other English as a second or foreign language (ESL/EFL) contexts where high-stakes testing prevails, Hong Kong students are highly exam-oriented and expect teachers to teach to the test. Because there is no direct assessment on literature in the English language curriculum, many teachers find it challenging to balance CLT through literature and exam preparation. To address this issue, this article describes an innovation of teaching ESL through songs by ‘packaging’ it as exam practice to engage exam-oriented students in CLT. A series of activities derived from the song *Seasons in the Sun* was implemented in the ESL classrooms in a secondary school in Hong Kong. Based on the author’s observations and reflections informed by teachers’ and students’ comments, the students were first motivated, at least instrumentally, by the relevance of the activities to the listening paper in the public exam when they saw the similarities between the classroom tasks and past exam questions. Once the students felt motivated, they were more easily engaged in a variety of CLT activities, which encouraged the use of English for authentic and meaningful communication. This article offers pedagogical implications for ESL/EFL teachers to implement CLT through literature in exam-oriented contexts.

Keywords

Communicative language teaching, exam-oriented students, high-stakes exam, Hong Kong, learning English through songs, teaching English through literature

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Introduction

Literature in language teaching has been promoted in English as a second or foreign language (ESL/EFL) classrooms worldwide (Paran, 2008). Traditionally, Literature with a big 'L' was recognised as the 'best', 'classical' and 'approved' works which have 'constituted the literary canon deemed by authority to be fit to study' (Maley, 2001: 180–181). To go beyond the conventional literary canon, scholars have promoted using literature with a small 'l' such as poems, songs and short stories to teach ESL/EFL. Picken (2007) highlighted 'authenticity' as a virtue of literature for communicative language teaching (CLT). Literary texts are authentic for students to be exposed to natural language use, with the incorporation of grammar and language functions. They can also stimulate students' imagination, develop their critical abilities, and increase their emotional awareness and confidence in expressing personal ideas using the target language (Hall, 2015).

In the recent education reform in Hong Kong, the use of literature, which is called 'language arts' in the senior secondary English language curriculum, is regarded as an innovation (Carless and Harfitt, 2013; Cheung and Hennebry-Leung, 2020). Four elective modules have been introduced – namely, drama, poems and songs, popular culture and short stories. According to the Curriculum Development Council (CDC) and Hong Kong Examinations and Assessment Authority (HKEAA) (2015), this initiative attempts to promote CLT, broaden students' English learning experiences and cater for their diverse needs and interests. Teachers are expected to adopt a student-centred, task-based and process-oriented approach to teach English through literature. Nevertheless, like many other Asian countries and increasingly in the West (Au, 2009), the learning environment in Hong Kong is exam-oriented and teacher-centred (Yung, 2019, 2020b). Because of this traditional mode of education, the introduction of literature is a rather novel and challenging concept. Complete learner autonomy, pure enjoyment and fully detaching the tasks from exams may lead to failure, because students are often exam-oriented and extrinsically motivated (Cheung and Hennebry-Leung, 2020). While a learner-centred and process-oriented approach should be adopted in CLT, students still demand to know how the task is related to exams. This tension led to the innovation to balance CLT through literature and exam preparation, as described in this article.

The Teaching Context

In an action research project, the author immersed himself in an elite, English-medium school in Hong Kong for a period of six weeks on a day-to-day basis to try out a series of CLT activities (Yung, 2020a, 2020c). One of the activities was to promote literature among senior secondary students. The school selected *Learning English through poems and songs* as one of their elective modules. As stipulated in the *Curriculum and assessment guide*:

This module introduces learners to a variety of poems and songs with themes that are of interest to them. Learners will engage in different activities that aim to develop their appreciation of the themes and emotions expressed in poems and songs, acquaint them with poetic language and features, enhance their cultural awareness, stimulate their imagination, and foster their creative use of English. (CDC and HKEAA, 2015: 35)

The author taught in two classes, one Secondary 4 (Grade 10) and one Secondary 5 (Grade 11). Each class had 32 Cantonese-speaking ESL students, aged 15–17. They all studied the local curriculum. At the end of Secondary 6 (Grade 12), they would sit for the Hong Kong Diploma of Secondary Education Examination (HKDSE), a high-stakes school-leaving exam for university admission.

Reason for the Innovation

In line with the findings in Carless and Harfitt's (2013: 182) study, there were tensions between enjoyable learning through literature and exam-oriented teaching. Despite students' generally positive attitude toward the electives, literature was 'taken less seriously because they did not count as part of the HKDSE'. The teachers in the school also expressed the same view as those in Tegge's (2018: 282) study, who did not use songs in language classes because they 'can't fit songs in with the official curriculum', in particular the public exam. These prompted the author to develop tasks that bridge the gap between the initiatives of CLT and the literature elective modules in the curriculum reform and senior secondary students' demand for exam-oriented practice.

Description of the Innovation

This section showcases the innovation of engaging exam-oriented ESL students in CLT through literature. Specifically, the teaching of English through songs was 'packaged' as exam practice, with the incorporation of a series of activities that encouraged the use of English for meaningful and authentic communication in a 70-minute ESL lesson.

Preparation for Teaching Materials

To prepare for the CLT tasks in the *Learning English through poems and songs* module, an English song *Seasons in the Sun* was chosen. A reason for using a song rather than a poem was that songs are usually short and catchy, and their length makes class time allocation more manageable and helps maintain the interest and patience of students (Tsang, 2020). In addition to practicality, songs are rich in educational value (Davis, 2017; Şevik, 2011). As lyrics are not extracts or simplified texts and meanings are packed into very few words, songs are suitable for teaching interpretative procedures (Hall, 2015; Paran, 2008). Students can focus on discovering the general meaning of the text and enjoy the rhymes and rhythm (Lems, 2018). Moreover, using songs in the ESL classroom encourages extensive and intensive listening, promotes creativity and use of imagination, stimulates discussion of attitudes and feelings, provides a relaxed classroom atmosphere and brings a variety and fun to language teaching and learning (Griffiths, 2013; Tsang, 2020).

Seasons in the Sun was selected because the linguistic difficulty of its lyrics was appropriate for the group of secondary ESL students. It was also suitable for students of different cultural or literary background because of its universal theme of 'life and death'. The version sung by a popular boy band Westlife was selected because Westlife's music

video clearly illustrates the lip movement of the singers, facilitating the learning of pronunciation of certain words in a post-listening activity.

To make the CLT activities more relevant to students' expectation of exam preparation, the format and question types of the listening task followed closely one of the four compulsory tasks in the HKDSE listening paper. Among others which usually involve fill-in-the-blank or multiple-choice questions, this task is considered the most challenging because it requires students to give more open-ended and extended answers.

Pre-Listening Stage: Briefing and Scaffolding the Students

In the briefing of the listening task, evidence from past exam papers and official exam reports from the HKEAA were shown to the students to draw relevance to the public exam. A recent exam report was analysed to justify how the listening task was designed based on the HKDSE format: 'This task, consisting mainly of questions requiring fuller answers, was designed to be more challenging for candidates. The content was more challenging intellectually and required a greater amount of interpretation and inference' (HKEAA, 2019: 177). Once the students saw the similarities between the listening task and past exam papers and realised the task was considered challenging in HKDSE, as stipulated in the exam report, they were more easily motivated, at least instrumentally, to engage in the upcoming activities.

For scaffolding, students were presented with the song title, and were asked to elicit as many words that immediately came to their mind as possible. The task was open for multiple interpretations and did not involve right or wrong answers. Students were prepared to enter the mood of the song by imagining they were leaving their hometown for further studies and choosing a person to say goodbye to. This helped the students to learn to familiarise themselves with a given situation as required in the HKDSE listening paper. On the other hand, this aimed to arouse students' interest as the process was relaxing and related to them as individuals through expressing their own ideas, feelings and attitudes. These served as a 'warm-up', introducing the subject matter to the students and preparing them for the main listening task.

While-Listening Stage: The Exam Practice

Instead of using songs for traditional gap-filling exercises commonplace in ESL classrooms (Tegge, 2018; Tsang, 2020), the listening task required students to answer questions based on their comprehension of the lyrics (Figure 1). In this regard, wh-word questions were used – for example, 'Who is the first person the man is saying goodbye to?', 'How old were they when they knew each other?' and 'What does the man see before he dies?'. This part adopted a formalist approach and was more structured (Klarer, 1999). It aimed to meet students' expectation of exam preparation. As in the HKDSE listening exam, the students were given 30 seconds to study the task. The song was then played once, and the students needed to jot down the answers while listening. At the end of the task, they had three minutes to tidy up their answers. The lyrics were then delivered to the students as a 'marking scheme'.

Although the purpose of this listening task was to fulfil students' demand for exam practice, what was more important was the CLT activities that immediately followed. In other words, in addition to checking the answers, the lyrics was used for analysis through class

7. What did the second person do to the man?

Figure 1. (Continued)

Answers written in the margins will not be marked.

8. What did they do together?
(a) _____
(b) _____

9. What does the man see before he dies?
(a) _____
(b) _____

Part 3

(8 marks)

10. Who is the third person the man is saying goodbye to?

11. What did the third person do to the man?
(a) _____
(b) _____

12. What would the third person do when the man was down?
(a) _____
(b) _____

13. What does the man see before he dies?
(a) _____
(b) _____

14. What is the season when the man is going to die?

END OF PAPER

Answers written in the margins will not be marked.

Figure 1. The while-listening task resembling the format of the HKDSE listening paper.

discussion. A stylistic approach was adopted to encourage students to use English for authentic communication (see online Appendix I). It enabled students to make meaningful interpretations of the text itself and expanded their knowledge and awareness of the language in general (Hall, 2015). Students paid conscious attention to details of linguistic features foregrounded in the lyrics, any deviance of language and repetitions, parallelism or other salient patternings that contributed significantly to meaning. For example, in the first stanza, students could look for rhymes (i.e. ‘friend’ and ‘ten’; ‘trees’, ‘ABC’s’ and ‘knees’), explain why present perfect and past tenses were used (e.g. ‘We’ve known each other since we were nine or ten’ and ‘we climbed hills and trees’), and guess the

meaning of ‘skinned our hearts’ and ‘skinned our knees’. In the chorus, they could identify parallel structure such as ‘we had joy, we had fun, we had seasons in the sun’ and discuss the purpose and effect for doing so.

The stylistic approach did not only teach the students the language per se, but also what the language can do (Hall, 2015; Paran, 2008). Informed by the idea of New Criticism, multiple meanings and paradox were allowed (Klarer, 1999). As songs provide a personal context for affective involvement, students should be able to express their feelings, thoughts and experiences without being confined to the biological data or psychological conditions of the author. The analysis of the lyrics also made the students aware of how words and sounds are patterned to highlight specific effects and express certain purposes (Erten, 2015; Şevik, 2011).

After the analysis of the lyrics, students were shown the karaoke music video of the song to sing together. Karaoke is popular among adolescents, so it can be an appealing activity for students to use English in the classroom (Erten, 2015; Lems, 2018). Since there are many close-up shots in the video, students could pay attention to the lip movement of the singers and imitate their articulation of certain words. Pronunciations of consonants and vowels that Cantonese speakers generally find challenging were highlighted – for example, the voiced ‘th’ [ð] in ‘other’ and ‘the’, the consonant blend ‘bl’ in ‘black’, the tongue rolling ‘r’ in ‘air’ in British accent, the ‘l’ after a vowel in ‘Michelle’ and [au] in ‘down’ (Figure 2).

Students were also encouraged to watch the video online at home and search for other songs that were interesting and meaningful to them for more personalised self-access learning. The lesson concluded with the teacher emphasising how the task had encouraged students to use English for authentic communication as well as prepared them for the public exam.

Reflection and Pedagogical Implications

Based on the author’s reflection informed by his observation, ongoing dialogue with the teachers in the school, and students’ views solicited in focus-group interviews,¹ the activities successfully engaged exam-oriented students in CLT. Despite being part of the curriculum, literature originally did not appeal to students, because it was considered simply interesting, without any direct relationship with exams (Carless and Harfitt, 2013). As a teacher commented: ‘Maybe because they are senior, they expect everything to be about the exam. [. . .] If you cannot concretely point out the relationship with the exam, they won’t be interested’ (Teacher 3, individual interview). Focus-group interviews with the students also revealed their exam-oriented attitude:

HKDSE is actually a very big challenge, and is the most important reason that encourages me to learn English as I need to face HKDSE and I want to get high score in English. (M1, FG2)

Although students want to use English mostly for authentic communication, we also have to face the fact that we have to . . . strive for HKDSE. (M2, FG2)

By ‘packaging’ the listening task as exam practice, students’ motivation was triggered, and they became more easily engaged in the CLT activities, which created ample

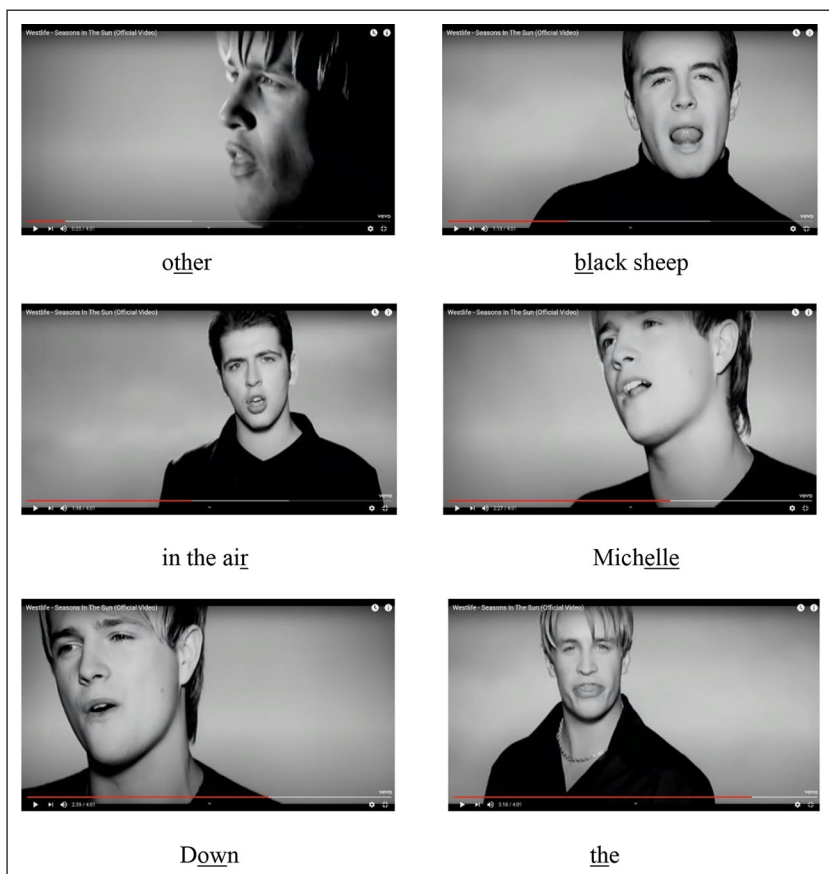


Figure 2. Screen shots of the music video to demonstrate lip movement.

Source: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Xdv83MFjd7U>.

opportunities for them to speak English (e.g. discussing the stylistics, expressing their feelings). The ‘balance’ between exam preparation and using English for communication was valued by the students:

I think there should be a balance between learning English for authentic communication and learning the skills to answer the questions in the test because although HKDSE is really important, we have to use authentic communication to communicate with the people from other countries in the future. (M2, FG2)

Based on observation, most students continued to engage in the CLT activities even after the ‘exam practice’. This was also shown in the interviews:

Regarding the issue whether the activities can motivate us to use English for authentic communication, my answer is yes, as I think now the reason for me to learn English is not just

for the HKDSE exam . . . These activities made me realise that the use of English is not just limited to lessons or just on exam papers, but more importantly, it is a communication bridge that makes us familiar with the real world. (M1, FG5)

The activities provided an opportunity for us to speak English through different ways. (M3, FG3)

They also found the lesson fun and relaxing when they were encouraged to express their thoughts and feelings freely in the ESL classroom. In case some students become disengaged immediately after the exam practice, teachers may need to emphasise how the follow-up CLT activities are related to the exam from time to time. For example, the students could practise the skills to answer different types of questions in the HKDSE listening paper, learn how to identify rhymes in reading, develop skills to justify their views and feelings in writing, and improve their pronunciation of words highlighted in the exam report as commonly mispronounced in the speaking exam.

A limitation was that because the song involves life and death, the discussion might evoke unstable emotions among some students who may have had a negative experience (e.g. having lost a significant other). It is, therefore, important for teachers to observe the emotional state of every student and encourage them to be positive. Alternatively, other songs can be selected to engage students with less sensitive topics (see, e.g., Lems, 2018). On the pragmatic side, teachers may strengthen the relevance of the tasks to the public exam by using a song that has appeared in the past exam (Yung, 2020c). In this case, after the exam practice task, teachers may analyse the exam report with the students and suggest how they can better prepare for the public exam.

This paper does not devalue literature as another text for exam practice. On the contrary, the ‘exam practice’ is merely a ‘package’. This was evidenced by the substantial time spent on the post-listening stage with follow-up activities focusing on the appreciation of the song through CLT. Teachers should bear in mind that the core value of using literature in ESL/EFL classrooms is not for assessment but cultivating whole-person development and enjoyment in language learning. Learning a language entails more than just an intellectual process and is tied to values and emotions. Teachers, therefore, should strike a balance between CLT and exam preparation. As there is no ‘one-size-fits-all’ approach in teaching English through literature, ESL/EFL teachers should understand more about using literature as a resource and adjust classroom practice to suit the learners’ diverse needs from time to time.

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Supplemental material

Supplemental material for this article is available online.

Note

1. The focus-group interviews were conducted after the CLT activities. Sixty-four students, in groups of four, responded to a series of questions – for example, ‘Do you like the class activities?’, ‘Have the activities motivated you to use English for authentic communication?’ – and explained why. The interviews were student-led without the teacher in the classroom so that they could express their views freely. All the interviews were audio-recorded for transcription by research assistants. The researcher only read the transcripts without any identifiable information of the students.

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